But once they come together, the distrust that would be natural in other circumstances was dissipated by their innate bonding. They realized, too, that their collective solidarity had a larger purpose because it resonated throughout the kingdom and allowed them to render their expected service. The ability of those who share values and beliefs to come together for greater good should, therefore, never be underestimated. Particularly once they have learnt to accommodate differences and appreciate a larger purpose, the groundwork is laid for a lasting convergence.

If we are now to consider the campaign underway to recover Queen Sita, Lord Rama brought together a diverse group of players to advance a shared objective. Naturally, the other side made all efforts to sow dissension among this differentiated group. In this particular case, Ravana sent the sorcerer Suka to create discord between monkeys and men. However, Suka failed to achieve his objective, as his insinuations that men do not treat other creatures fairly was strongly rebutted by the monkeys. In fact, his efforts end up counterproductively, bringing into open the conflict of interests of monkeys and demons in the forests that they inhabit together.

Ravana made another attempt with the monkey-prince Angada, invoking what he claimed was a deep friendship with his father Vali. He sought to exploit what would normally be a grudge, since Lord Rama had killed Angada's father. This too failed, as much a result of self-awareness on the prince's part as of the mutual confidence that was steadily encouraged by Rama. In its own way, the Ramayana is also a tale of the power of comfort and convergence as it is of the importance of global good.

THE CHANGING BIG PICTURE

In many ways, I bear personal testimony to the evolution of the Quad. This goes back to 2005–06 as witness to the early efforts to develop it that were particularly driven by Japan. After the 2007 effort, many of us shared the disappointment of an aborted venture. It was, however, typical of an era of ambivalence. A decade later, we were now in a position to both assess the changed geopolitical landscape and learn from the lessons of the past. A meeting at the Foreign Secretary's level in New York in 2017 was a signal that our leaderships had decided to give a new life to an old idea. The difference was also that Quad members now had greater clarity about global deficits and a stronger resolve to contribute. This was probably true of all but most marked in the case of India.

By 2019, the consensus was developing that the time had come to raise the group to a political level. I now had the privilege of participating as the EAM. The 2020 meeting of the Quad foreign ministers in Japan was particularly significant, taking place as it did in the midst of Covid. Just when the professional pessimists were beginning to pronounce on its